

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract from an American newspaper:

Digital devices deprive brain of needed downtime

Smartphones are now powerful computers with high-speed Internet connections, letting people get more work done and have more fun, relieving the boredom of exercising, standing in a queue, or sitting on a train.

The technology makes the tiniest windows of time entertaining, and potentially productive. But scientists point to an unexpected side effect: when people keep their brains busy with digital input, they are sacrificing 'quiet time' that could allow them to better learn and remember information, or come up with new ideas.

'Almost certainly, resting the brain lets it go over experiences it's had, solidify them and turn them into permanent long-term memories,' said Loren Frank, a specialist in learning and memory. He believes that when the brain is constantly stimulated, 'you prevent this learning process.'

At the University of Michigan, a study found that people learned significantly better after a walk in nature than after a walk in a dense urban environment, suggesting that processing a barrage of information leaves people fatigued.

Even though people feel entertained, even relaxed, when they pass a moment at the bus stop by catching a quick video clip, they might be over-tiring their brains, scientists say.

Your group wants to give a presentation about the ways that smartphones and tablets are changing the lives of young people in Hong Kong. You may want to talk about:

- how using them affects people's brains
- how using them affects people's behaviour
- how using them affects people's relationships with others
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like using smartphones?
2. How should people spend their time when travelling on public transport?
3. Why do people like using smartphones so much?
4. Do you think people in Hong Kong use their smartphones too much?
5. Are smartphones the most important technological product nowadays?
6. Do you think smartphones help or prevent learning?
7. Do you think smartphones are changing society?
8. Do you think smartphones damage creativity?